

AI Harness Hackathon 2026

Standardised Makefile-Based Evaluation Setup

Participant Technical Requirements & Evaluation Guidelines

To ensure a **uniform, reproducible, and technically consistent evaluation process**, every participating team is required to include a standardised **Makefile** at the root of its submission repository.

The Makefile will provide the evaluation team with a consistent interface to configure, initialise, test, and execute your AI Harness.

1. Mandatory Makefile

Every submission **must contain** the following file at the root of the repository:

Makefile

The Makefile must expose the following commands:

make setup

make run

make test

Teams may implement these commands according to their own technology stack and architecture, but their purpose must remain consistent.

Command	Purpose
make setup	Install and configure all required dependencies
make run	Initialise and launch the AI Harness
make test	Execute the team's test/evaluation procedure
make clean	Remove generated artefacts, where applicable

Minimum Requirement

At minimum, the following must work successfully:

make setup

make run

2. API Key Configuration

The evaluation environment will provide the required API credential through an environment variable.

The variable name will be:

AI_API_KEY

You MUST NOT hard-code:

- API keys
- Access tokens
- Passwords
- Secrets

- Authentication credentials

inside your:

- Source code
- Makefile
- .env files
- Documentation
- Configuration files committed to Git

The evaluator will provide the credential at runtime:

```
export AI_API_KEY="<PROVIDED_API_KEY>"
```

Your application must read the credential from this environment variable.

For example:

setup:

```
@echo "Setting up environment..."
# installation commands
```

run:

```
@echo "Starting AI Harness..."
AI_API_KEY=$(AI_API_KEY) <team-run-command>
```

test:

```
@echo "Running tests..."
AI_API_KEY=$(AI_API_KEY) <team-test-command>
```

The exact implementation may differ depending on your technology stack.

3. Model Requirement

The AI Harness submitted for evaluation must use **text-only language models**.

The evaluation input will be provided as text.

Your implementation must **not require**:

- Image input
- Audio input
- Video input
- Multimodal processing
- Any other non-text modality

This requirement ensures that all teams are evaluated under the same modality constraints.

4. Model Configuration

The model configuration used by your AI Harness must be clearly defined within the application or its configuration files.

If the Organising Committee specifies a particular model or model family for the official evaluation, teams must use the prescribed model.

Teams must **not substitute another model during evaluation** unless explicitly authorised by the Organising Committee.

The API credential will continue to be supplied externally through:

AI_API_KEY

Your implementation must therefore allow the credential to be supplied **without modifying the submitted source code**.

5. Standard Evaluation Procedure

The evaluation team will follow a common procedure for all submissions.

Step 1 — Obtain the Repository

The evaluator will obtain the team's submitted repository.

Step 2 — Configure API Credential

The evaluator will run:

```
export AI_API_KEY="<PROVIDED_API_KEY>"
```

Step 3 — Setup

The evaluator will run:

```
make setup
```

This command must install and configure everything required to run the project.

Step 4 — Launch

The evaluator will run:

```
make run
```

This must launch the team's AI Harness in its intended evaluation mode.

Step 5 — Evaluation

The prescribed GitHub issue/test case will then be supplied to the running harness according to the official evaluation procedure.

Where applicable, the evaluator may also run:

```
make test
```

6. TUI Requirements

Teams implementing a **Terminal User Interface (TUI)** must ensure that the TUI can be launched through:

```
make run
```

The evaluator should **not have to discover team-specific commands** to initialise your TUI.

The expected flow is:

Submitted Repository



Configure AI_API_KEY



make setup



make run



Standard Evaluation Environment



Evaluation Issue / Test Case



Harness Execution



Result

Teams are free to determine:

- TUI design
- Navigation
- Layout
- Interaction model
- Internal architecture
- Visual presentation

However, the **initialisation and execution interface must remain standardised**.

7. Evaluation Environment

The Organising Committee will establish a standard evaluation environment.

The environment will provide, as applicable:

- Prescribed runtime environment
- Designated API credential
- Prescribed text-only model
- Relevant GitHub repository/issue
- Required testing infrastructure
- Standard execution proceed Absolutely — here is a **participant-facing document version**, cleaned up and formatted so you can directly send it to teams.

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- Standard execution procedure

The objective is to minimise differences caused by individual machines, terminal configurations, or local environments.

8. Credential Security

The following practices are **strictly prohibited**:

Hard-coded API keys

Committed credentials

Credentials embedded in source code

Credentials embedded in Makefiles

Credentials committed in .env files

Credentials included in documentation

If environment variables are required for local development, teams may include:

.env.example

For example:

AI_API_KEY=

Do not include an actual API credential.

9. Environment Independence

Your Makefile should encapsulate the setup procedure required to initialise your project.

The evaluator should not ordinarily be required to:

- Manually install undocumented dependencies
- Determine the correct runtime command
- Modify source code
- Modify dependency files
- Manually alter configuration files
- Enter credentials into source files
- Contact the team for routine setup assistance

All dependencies required for execution should be properly declared and handled through the setup procedure.

10. Reproducible Execution

Teams should ensure, to the extent reasonably practicable, that their AI Harness behaves consistently under the same evaluation conditions.

If your implementation uses:

- Randomness
- Configurable parameters
- Random seeds
- Variable execution settings

that materially affect the output, the relevant configuration should be documented or controlled within the submitted project.

The evaluation environment will remain consistent across teams to the extent technically feasible.

11. Evaluation Independence

Evaluation will be conducted using the **submitted repository** and the standard evaluation environment.

The evaluation team will **not modify your implementation** merely to make it executable. If a submission cannot be initialised using the prescribed Makefile interface and standard environment, the issue may be documented and handled according to the official Hackathon evaluation and scoring policy.

12. Standard Evaluator Workflow

The intended evaluation workflow is:

```
git clone <TEAM_REPOSITORY>
```

```
cd <TEAM_REPOSITORY>
```

```
export AI_API_KEY="<PROVIDED_API_KEY>"
```

```
make setup
```

```
make run
```

The evaluator will then proceed with the prescribed evaluation issue/test case.

Where automated testing is supported:

```
make test
```

may also be executed according to the evaluation protocol.

13. Final Submission Checklist

Before submitting your project, **test it in a clean environment**.

Your team must verify that:

```
make setup
```

runs successfully.

Then verify:

```
make run
```

successfully launches your AI Harness.

Also verify, where applicable:

```
make test
```

Your repository should contain:

```
your-project/
```

```
|
```

```
|— Makefile          ← REQUIRED
```

```
|— README.md
```

```
|— source-code/
```

```
|— configuration-files/
```

```
|— dependency-files/
```

```
|— ...
```

The Makefile must be located at the **root of the repository**.

14. Important

The Makefile is an **essential component of your final submission**.

Every team is responsible for ensuring that the submitted repository can be set up and launched using the standard interface.

The evaluator should be able to do:

```
export AI_API_KEY="<PROVIDED_API_KEY>"
```

make setup

make run

without modifying your source code or manually configuring your project.

Failure to provide a functional standardised setup and execution interface may affect the ability of the evaluation team to execute your submission and will be handled according to the official Hackathon evaluation policy.

Final Requirement

Before the submission deadline, **please test your repository from a clean environment** and confirm that:

make setup

make run

work successfully.

Your Makefile is part of the submission and will be used during evaluation.